Salma Pir T. Rasul

Atty. Salma Pir T. Rasul is a Filipino lawyer, academic, and civic leader whose career has been defined by one big, persistent mission: making Islamic law comprehensible, accessible, and respected within the Philippine legal system. As both a practitioner and educator, she works at the intersection of civil law and Shari'ah, translating between two legal worlds that too often talk past each other. She serves as **Programs Director of the Philippine Center for Islam and Democracy (PCID)** and as the designated **Director for Islamic Law Studies at the University of the Philippines Law Center (UPLC)**, making her one of the most institutionally grounded authorities on Muslim personal law in the country. She is the daughter of the late Senator Santanina Tillah Rasul, the first Muslim woman elected to the Philippine Senate, and the late Ambassador Abraham A. Rasul Sr., and the sister of peace advocate Amina Rasul-Bernardo, president of PCID.

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EARLY LIFE AND FAMILY BACKGROUND

Salma Pir Rasul comes from a family that has long been at the center of Bangsamoro public life. Her mother, Senator Santanina Tillah Rasul, made history in 1987 as the first Muslim woman elected to the Philippine Senate, serving two terms until 1995 and authoring landmark legislation on civil service reform, gender

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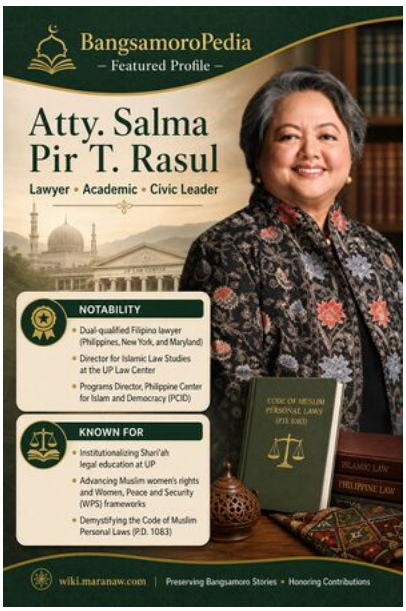


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Personal Information

Full Name: Salma Pir T. Rasul

Ethnicity

Tausug

Region of Origin

Sulu Archipelago, Bangsamoro

Education

B.S. Business Economics, University of the Philippines School of Economics
Juris Doctor (formerly LLB), University of the Philippines College of Law Bar Admissions: Philippines; New York and Maryland (U.S.)

Profession

Lawyer, Academic, Civic Leader

Key Affiliations

equality, and women's rights before passing away in November 2024 at the age of 94. Her father, the late Ambassador Abraham A. Rasul Sr., was a Tausug leader who served as Philippine Ambassador to Saudi Arabia. Growing up in this household meant growing up around diplomacy, legislation, and grassroots advocacy as everyday realities rather than distant ideals.

Salma is the youngest of six children. Her siblings include her sister Amina Rasul-Bernardo, a prominent peace advocate who serves as president of PCID, and four brothers: Fatima, Amroussi, Abraham Jr., and Yusuf. The family legacy, shaped by both public service and a deep rootedness in Tausug culture, gave Salma an early and grounded sense of what it meant to carry the concerns of the Bangsamoro people forward.

ETHNIC AFFILIATION AND CULTURAL HERITAGE

Atty. Rasul belongs to the **Tausug** people, the indigenous community historically known as the "people of the current," rooted in the Sulu Archipelago in Southwestern Mindanao. The Tausug have long been known for their seafaring traditions, distinct legal and cultural customs, and a strong sense of collective identity shaped by centuries of resistance and self-governance.

Her Tausug heritage is not incidental to her legal career; it's foundational. The traditional customs, or *Adat*, of the Sulu region inform the way she approaches questions of Muslim personal law, community rights, and the gaps between state legislation and lived Islamic practice. For her, working with the Code of Muslim Personal Laws isn't just a professional specialty; it's also a personal responsibility.

Programs Director, Philippine Center for Islam and Democracy (PCID) Director for Islamic Law Studies, UP Law Center (UPLC) Vice President for Legal Affairs, ASEAN Society Philippines Member, National Council, NAMFREL

Family

Daughter of the late Senator Santanina Tillah Rasul and the late Ambassador Abraham A. Rasul Sr. Sister of Amina Rasul-Bernardo

Notability

Dual-qualified Filipino lawyer (Philippines, New York, and Maryland) specializing in Islamic jurisprudence and Shari'ah law; Director for Islamic Law Studies at the University of the Philippines Law Center; Programs Director, Philippine Center for Islam and Democracy (PCID)

Known For

Institutionalizing Shari'ah legal education at UP; advancing Muslim women's rights and Women, Peace and Security (WPS) frameworks in Southeast Asia; demystifying the Code of Muslim Personal Laws (P.D. 1083) for practitioners, judges, and policymakers

EDUCATION

Atty. Rasul earned her undergraduate degree in **Business Economics** from the University of the Philippines School of Economics in Diliman, a program known for its rigorous analytical training. She then pursued law at the **University of the Philippines College of Law**, completing her Juris Doctor (formerly the Bachelor of Laws or LLB), the country's most prestigious legal training ground.

What sets her apart globally is her additional bar admissions in the **United States**: she has passed the bar examinations in both **New York** and **Maryland**, making her a dual-qualified lawyer cleared to practice in the Philippines and in two major U.S. jurisdictions. This breadth of legal credentialing reflects the same orientation that defines her career: an insistence on engaging the law not just locally but across systems and borders.

CAREER AND PROFESSIONAL TRAJECTORY

Philippine Center for Islam and Democracy (PCID)

Atty. Rasul serves as **Programs Director** of PCID, a non-partisan, non-profit think tank established in 2002 and formally incorporated as a center in 2010. PCID is dedicated to studying the relationship between Islamic and democratic political thought, and to supporting peace, development, and human rights in Muslim communities. In this role, she designs and manages programs that promote democratic participation, counter extremist narratives, and build civic capacities within Muslim communities across the Philippines. Her work at PCID also includes producing accessible educational materials that explain democratic principles through an Islamic framework, a direct response to fringe voices that have long claimed Islam and democracy are incompatible.

University of the Philippines Law Center

At the UPLC, Atty. Rasul carries the designation of **Director for Islamic Law Studies**, where she oversees institutional efforts around the administration of Muslim personal laws. She previously served as Programs Development Consultant at the UPLC's Institute for the Administration of Justice. She also lectures for the **Mandatory Continuing Legal Education (MCLE)** program of the UPLC, ensuring that practicing Filipino lawyers get up to speed on the intersections of civil law and Shari'ah. Additionally, she has taught at **Lyceum of the Philippines College of Law**.

Consulting and International Work

Her expertise has made her a sought-after consultant for international institutions. She has done consulting work for **UN Women** on the Women, Peace and Security (WPS) agenda for Southeast Asia, and for the **United Nations Development Programme (UNDP)** on preventing violent extremism (PVE), Shari'ah law, and peacebuilding. She has also participated as a delegate and expert speaker at international forums, including the **International Law and Religion Symposium** hosted by Brigham Young University.

MAJOR WORKS AND LEGAL ADVOCACY

Shari'ah Jurisprudence and P.D. 1083

Atty. Rasul has been a consistent voice for strengthening the implementation of **Presidential Decree No. 1083**, the Code of Muslim Personal Laws of the Philippines. Enacted in 1977, the Code governs matters of family, marriage, inheritance, and personal status for Filipino Muslims, but it has historically been underserved in terms of trained practitioners, accessible interpretation, and coordination with civil courts. Her work has focused on training Shari'ah court judges and lawyers to apply the Code competently and to protect the rights of individuals, particularly women, navigating both the Shari'ah and civil court systems.

Women, Peace and Security

Atty. Rasul has authored field manuals and programmatic frameworks that place Muslim women at the center of conflict prevention and peacebuilding work. Her perspective, that women approach conflict resolution with a fundamentally collaborative and community-grounded orientation, shapes her contributions to PVE discourse in

the Philippines and across Southeast Asia. This work is part of the broader Women, Peace and Security agenda that she has helped develop through her UN consulting engagements.

Federalism and Legal Reform

She has also been part of the **study group on Federalism** organized by the Local Government Development Foundation and the Konrad Adenauer Stiftung, contributing a Muslim Mindanao perspective to ongoing debates about constitutional restructuring and regional self-governance.

INSTITUTIONAL AFFILIATIONS

Beyond her core roles at PCID and UPLC, Atty. Rasul is active in several significant institutions:

NAMFREL: She is a member of the National Council of the **National Citizens' Movement for Free Elections**, a civil society organization that monitors elections and advocates for democratic integrity in the Philippines.

ASEAN Society Philippines: She serves as **Vice President for Legal Affairs**, contributing to diplomatic and socio-cultural cooperation across Southeast Asia.

UP Women Lawyers Circle: She is a member of the board of trustees of this organization dedicated to women in the legal profession.

LEGACY AND SIGNIFICANCE

Atty. Salma Pir Rasul's contribution to Philippine legal history can be summed up this way: she made Islamic law legible to a legal establishment that had long treated it as peripheral. By institutionalizing Shari'ah legal education at the University of the Philippines, the country's flagship state university, she ensured that Muslim personal law would be studied, debated, and developed alongside civil law rather than apart from it.

Her family name carries enormous weight in Bangsamoro history, but Atty. Rasul has built her own standing through decades of institutional work, academic writing, and field engagement. She represents a generation of Muslim Filipino professionals who have moved between local community life, national institutions, and international platforms without losing the thread that connects all three.

For the growing generation of Muslim women entering law and public service, her career is a working blueprint: rigorous, principled, and deeply rooted in community.

SEE ALSO

- Amina Rasul-Bernardo
- Santanina Tillah Rasul
- Philippine Center for Islam and Democracy (PCID)
- University of the Philippines Law Center (UPLC)
- Presidential Decree No. 1083 (Code of Muslim Personal Laws)
- Bangsamoro

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